

Marriage did nothing to lessen Elvira's wild outbursts of jealousy. In 1908, she became obsessed with the idea that a young maid at Torre del Lago, Doria Manfredi, was having an affair with Puccini. Her pitiless harassment and defamation of Doria drove the poor girl to suicide. A postmortem showed that Doria died a virgin. The maid's family took legal action against Elvira, before being bought off. The incident caused an immense scandal in the press, damaging Puccini's reputation.

In 1910, the composer completed *La fanciulla del West*, which was commissioned by the Metropolitan Opera House in New York, where Puccini's friend Toscanini had become the principal conductor (see [box](#)). Although some people saw incongruity in an Italian opera that was set in the American West, the work brought Puccini his last wholehearted artistic and popular triumph during his lifetime.

In the US, Puccini was a stellar celebrity; in Italy some felt his music had become "Germanic." When Italy entered into World War I in 1915 as an enemy of Germany and Austria, he was working on a comic opera, *La rondine*, and appearing in public with a German mistress. His failure to engage with the Italian war effort was shown up by contrast with Toscanini, who played music for the troops in range of enemy artillery fire. The friendship between the composer and the conductor temporarily lapsed. Puccini had long been working on an ambitious triptych of one-act operas. This came to fruition as *Il trittico*, first performed at the Metropolitan Opera House in 1918. Only one of these short operas, the comic *Gianni Schicchi*, showed the composer at his best.